Topic 14 — Cultural Heritage

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Tangible Cultural Heritage | Intangible Cultural Heritage | UNESCO World Heritage (विश्व धरोहर) Sites | UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage | UNESCO World Heritage Sites in India | UNESCO Intangible Heritage (अभौतिक विरासत) List (India)

Sources: UNESCO WH Convention 1972, ICH Convention 2003, ASI, Ministry of Culture, WHC inscriptions to July 2026, UPPCS Prelims 2018–2025 **Last verified:** August 2026

Current Affairs

- **Moidams** (मोइदाम) of Charaideo, Assam, entered the World Heritage list in **2024** as India's **43rd** property.
- **Maratha (मराठा) Military Landscapes** entered in **2025** as the **44th**. The serial covers **12** forts: eleven in Maharashtra and **Gingee** in Tamil Nadu (तमिलनाडु).
- **Sarnath** (सारनाथ) was inscribed in **July 2026** as India's **45th** property and Uttar Pradesh (उत्तर प्रदेश)'s **fourth**.
- **Deepavali** (दीपावली) entered UNESCO ICH on **10 December 2025** as India's **16th** element, at 20.COM at the Red Fort (लाल किला), Delhi.

Culture origin theories (quick pair)

Two standard explanations of how culture develops appear in multi-statement stems:

Theory	Core claim
Idealistic Theory	Culture grows from **divine inspiration**, intuition, or higher ideas perceived by individuals or groups.
Materialistic Theory	**Physical environment**, climate, and **means of production** shape culture first.

- Vedic culture is **not** only a religious product. Material conditions (pastoral–agrarian life, geography, technology) also shaped it. A statement that Vedic culture developed *only* from religious beliefs is **false**.

UKPCS Prelims 2025

Q. UKPCS Prelims 2025, Q52

Which of the following UNESCO World Heritage Sites is/are located in Uttarakhand (उत्तराखंड)?

A. Valley of Flowers (फूलों की घाटी) B. Kaziranga (काजीरंगा) National Park C. Mountain Railways of India D. Nanda Devi (नंदा देवी) National Park

A. A only B. A and B only C. A, B and C only D. A and D only

Show answer

Logic: Kaziranga and Mountain Railways are WHS sites outside Uttarakhand. **Ans: D (Series B provisional key).** Valley of Flowers and Nanda Devi form one WHS property in Uttarakhand. Kaziranga is in Assam; Mountain Railways are not in UK.

14.1 Tangible Cultural Heritage

Tangible heritage (भौतिक) is physical cultural property: a monument, a site, a city, a cave, or a museum object. ASI protection and UNESCO listing are different doors.

- Tangible heritage is material. A tourist can photograph it. An archaeologist can excavate it.
- **Immovable tangible heritage** comprises built monuments, archaeological ruins, historic (ऐतिहासिक) cities, rock-cut (शैल-कट) caves, temple complexes, and cultural landscapes.
- **Movable tangible heritage** encompasses museum artifacts, manuscripts, numismatic collections, and protected antiquities.
- **ASI** protects monuments under the **AMASR Act, 1958**. About **3,600+** are centrally protected. That badge is **not** a UNESCO tag.
- The **Antiquities and Art Treasures Act, 1972** covers smuggling and ownership of movable heritage.
- State archaeology (पुरातत्व) departments protect a second, larger set of monuments.
- To combat atmospheric pollution that discolours the Taj Mahal's white marble, the government demarcated the **Taj Trapezium Zone (TTZ)** (ताज ट्रपेज़ियम ज़ोन) as a 10,400 sq km protective environmental buffer around Agra.
- Encroachment, tourist wear and illegal digging are the other three threats.
- Conservation means structure, chemistry, documentation and a **buffer zone** (बफर क्षेत्र). It does not mean a WHS certificate by itself.
- A natural park can be tangible in the physical sense and still be classed as a **natural** WHS.

> **Logic:** Taj Mahal = tangible. Ramlila / Kumbh / Deepavali = intangible**. Never swap.

14.2 Intangible Cultural Heritage

Intangible heritage is living culture. It exists only while people transmit it. UNESCO uses five domains.

- Intangible heritage is practice, not stone. It dies when the last skilled community stops teaching it.
- UNESCO's five domains are oral tradition, performing arts, social practices and rituals, knowledge of nature, and traditional craft skill.

- Vedic chanting is oral. Kutiyattam and Ramlila are performance. Kumbh and Deepavali are social ritual (कर्मकाण्ड). Punjab Thathera metalwork is craft skill.
- The **1972** site convention could not save a chant or a dance. That gap created the **2003** ICH convention.
- Transmission is guru-shishya, festival cycles and family guilds (श्रेणी).
- **Sangeet Natak Akademi** (संगीत नाटक अकादेमी) keeps India's national ICH inventory. **IGNCA (कला केंद्र) Janapada (जनपद) Sampada** documents folk (लोक) and tribal (आदिवासी) practice.
- Classical dances are **not** named ICH elements. **Garba** (गरबा) is. **Ramlila** is. **Bharatanatyam** is not.
- **Nautanki** is UP folk theatre. It is **not** on the UNESCO list.
- **Holi** as a generic festival is **not** listed. **Deepavaliis** listed (**2025**).

> **Logic:** Bharatanatyam / Kathak / Nautanki are not named UNESCO ICH items. **Deepavali** is** (Dec 2025).

14.3 UNESCO World Heritage Sites

World Heritage sites sit under the **1972** Convention. They need Outstanding Universal Value. Types are cultural, natural, or mixed.

- The Convention Concerning the Protection of the World Cultural and Natural Heritage was adopted on **16 November 1972**.
- India is a State Party. Nomination starts on the national **Tentative List**.
- The **World Heritage Committee** has **21** rotating States. It votes to inscribe, defer or refer.
- The World Heritage Centre in **Paris** is the secretariat. It is not the Committee.
- **ICOMOS** evaluates cultural files. **IUCN** evaluates natural files.
- **OUV** means the site matters to all humanity, not only to one nation.
- Cultural criteria are **(i) to (vi)**. Natural criteria are **(vii) to (x)**.
- Criterion **(i)** is a masterpiece of human genius. The Taj is the textbook case.
- Criterion **(x)** pertains to threatened species (संकटग्रस्त प्रजातियां) and natural biodiversity habitats, exemplified by **Kaziranga National Park** as the prime sanctuary for the one-horned rhinoceros.
- A **mixed** site meets both sets. India's only mixed WHS (मिश्रित) is **Khangchendzonga National Park, Sikkim (2016)**.
- After inscription, the State files periodic conservation reports. A site in crisis can go on the **List of World Heritage in Danger**.
- **Manas** (Assam) was on the Danger List and was later removed after recovery.
- **World Heritage Day** is **18 April**. ICOMOS marks it. UPPCS has matched this date twice.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q25

Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer from the code given below.

List-I (Day) A. April 18 B. May 22 C. July 29 D. December 5

List-II (Event) 1. International Tiger Day 2. World Heritage Day 3. World Soil Day (विश्व मृदा दिवस) 4. International Day of Biodiversity

A. 4, 3, 2, 1 B. 1, 2, 3, 4 C. 2, 4, 1, 3 D. 3, 2, 1, 4

Show answer

Ans: C. April 18 = World Heritage Day. May 22 = Biodiversity. July 29 = Tiger. December 5 = Soil.

- **Ramsar (1971)** is wetlands. **UNESCO MAB (1971)** is biosphere reserves (जैवमंडल आरक्षित क्षेत्र). Neither is a WHS tag.
- **Keoladeo** (Rajasthan) is a rare double: natural WHS **1985** and a Ramsar site. **Sultanpur** (Haryana) is Ramsar only. **Rudrasagar** (Tripura) is Ramsar only.

> **Logic:** 1972 = World Heritage. 2003 = Intangible. 18 April = World Heritage Day**. Ramsar ≠ WHS.

14.4 UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage

Intangible heritage sits under the **2003** Convention. Lists are the Representative List and the Urgent Safeguarding List. Community consent is required.

- The Convention for the Safeguarding of the Intangible Cultural Heritage was adopted on **17 October 2003**. It entered into force in **2006**.
- India **ratified in 2005**.
- The **Representative List** shows living diversity. India's list lives in **14.6**.
- The **Urgent Safeguarding List** is for heritage close to extinction. Indian Prelims still drill the Representative List, not this one.
- Safeguarding means document, transmit, fund and teach. It does **not** mean freezing a ritual in 1900 form.
- A nomination needs **community consent**. The Intergovernmental Committee then decides.
- **Nawrouz / Novruz** is a **multinational** element. Indian Parsi and other communities share it. India is not the sole owner.
- Nodal ministry is **Culture**. SNA (संगीत नाटक) prepares many nomination files. Deepavali's 2025 file is the latest example.
- **20.COM** met at the **Red Fort, New Delhi**, in **December 2025**. It was the first time India hosted the ICH Committee. **Deepavali** was inscribed there.

> **Logic:** Do not reverse the years. **Sites = 1972. Living heritage = 2003**. Hosting 20.COM in Delhi does not make the Red Fort an ICH element.

14.5 UNESCO World Heritage Sites in India

India has **45** World Heritage properties as of July **2026**. The split is **37** cultural, **7** natural, and **1** mixed. India ranks sixth globally.

- India's first inscriptions were in **1983**: Ajanta (अजंता), Ellora (एलोरा), **Agra Fort** (आगरा किला) and the **Taj Mahal**.
- **UP has four** cultural WHS. The fourth is **Sarnath (2026)**. The first three are **Taj Mahal (1983)**, **Agra Fort (1983)** and **Fatehpur Sikri (1986)**.
- **Sarnath** is a serial property: **Chaukhandi Stupa (स्तूप)** plus the archaeological remains (Dhamek (धमेख), monasteries, Lion (सिंह) Capital findspot). It is **not** the Varanasi ghats.
- **Varanasi ghats** remain on the **Tentative List**. They are still **not** inscribed.
- **Moidams** of Charaideo, **Assam (2024)**, are Ahom mound burials. They were India's **43rd** WHS.
- **Maratha Military Landscapes (2025)** are **12** forts, mostly in **Maharashtra**, with **Gingee** in **Tamil Nadu**. They were the **44th**.
- **Sarnath (2026)** is the **45th**.
- **Santiniketan** (Birbhum, WB, **2023**) is Tagore's university town.
- **Sacred Ensembles of the Hoysalas (2023)** are **Belur (बेलूर), Halebidu (हलेबीडु) and Somanathapura** in Karnataka. They are not Ramappa.
- **Ramappa (Rudreshwara) Temple (2021)** was built under the Kakatiyas in **Telangana**, celebrated for its lightweight 'floating bricks' and carved sandbox foundation. Its UNESCO inscription was granted in **2021**.
- **Dholavira (2021)** is the Harappan (हड़प्पा) city in **Kutch, Gujarat**.
- **Nalanda (नालंदा) Mahavihara (महाविहार) (2016)** is Bihar. **Mahabodhi (महाबोधि), Bodh Gaya (बोधगया) (2002)** is a different Bihar site.
- **Jaipur City** was inscribed in **2019** at the WHC's **43rd** session (पंगु सत्र) in **Baku, Azerbaijan**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2019, Q35

Jaipur was listed as World Heritage Site by the UNESCO World Heritage Committee in its 43rd Session held in the city

A. Baku (Azerbaijan) B. Bishkek (Kyrgyzstan) C. Istanbul (Turkey) D. Marakesh (Morocco)

Show answer

Ans: A — Baku (Azerbaijan). Year **2019**. Jaipur is a historic **city** WHS, not only Jantar Mantar (2010).

- **Jantar Mantar, Jaipur (2010)** is a separate, earlier inscription from **Jaipur City (2019)**. Do not merge the two.
- **Hill Forts of Rajasthan (2013)** is a serial cultural property (Chittorgarh, Kumbhalgarh, Ranthambore (रणथंभौर), Amber, Jaisalmer, Gagron).
- **Mountain Railways of India** is one serial WHS: Darjeeling, Nilgiri (नीलगिरि), Kalka–Shimla.
- **Great Living Chola (चोल) Temples** is one serial WHS: Thanjavur (तंजावुर), Gangaikondacholapuram, Darasuram.

- **Le Corbusier's Capitol Complex, Chandigarh (2016)** is India's share (भाग) of a **transnational** serial property.
- Natural seven: **Kaziranga** (काजीरंगा) and **Manas** (Assam, 1985), **Keoladeo** (Rajasthan, 1985), **Sundarbans** (सुंदरबन) (WB, 1987), **Nanda Devi and Valley of Flowers** (Uttarakhand, 1988/2005), **Western Ghats** (पश्चिमी घाट) (2012, serial), **Great Himalayan National Park** (Himachal (हिमाचल), 2014).
- **Kaziranga is natural**, not cultural. One-horned rhino is the OUV story.
- **Khangchendzonga** is the **only mixed** Indian WHS. It is in **Sikkim**, not Nepal's side of the massif as the inscription.
- Lucknow monuments (Residency, Bara Imambara) are ASI/state heritage. They are **not** WHS.
- Khajuraho is **Madhya Pradesh (1986)**. Qutub and Humayun (हुमायूँ)'s Tomb and Red Fort are **Delhi**.

India WHS — complete inscribed list (45)

Site	State/UT	Year	Type
Agra Fort	**UP**	1983	Cultural
Ajanta Caves	Maharashtra	1983	Cultural
Ellora Caves	Maharashtra	1983	Cultural
Taj Mahal	**UP**	1983	Cultural
Sun Temple, Konark (कोणार्क)	Odisha	1984	Cultural
Group of Monuments, Mahabalipuram (महाबलीपुरम)	Tamil Nadu	1984	Cultural
Kaziranga National Park	Assam	1985	Natural
Manas Wildlife Sanctuary	Assam	1985	Natural
Keoladeo National Park	Rajasthan	1985	Natural
Churches and Convents of Goa (गोवा)	Goa	1986	Cultural
Khajuraho Group of Monuments	Madhya Pradesh	1986	Cultural
Group of Monuments, Hampi (हम्पी)	Karnataka	1986	Cultural
Fatehpur Sikri	**UP**	1986	Cultural
Group of Monuments, Pattadakal (पट्टदकल)	Karnataka	1987	Cultural
Elephanta (एलिफेंटा) Caves	Maharashtra	1987	Cultural
Great Living Chola Temples	Tamil Nadu	1987/2004	Cultural
Sundarbans National Park	West Bengal	1987	Natural
Nanda Devi and Valley of Flowers	Uttarakhand	1988/2005	Natural
Buddhist Monuments at Sanchi	Madhya Pradesh	1989	Cultural
Humayun's Tomb	Delhi	1993	Cultural

Site	State/UT	Year	Type
Qutb (कुतुब) Minar and its Monuments	Delhi	1993	Cultural
Mountain Railways of India	TN / WB / HP	1999/2005/2008	Cultural
Mahabodhi Temple Complex, Bodh Gaya	Bihar	2002	Cultural
Rock Shelters of Bhimbetka	Madhya Pradesh	2003	Cultural
Champaner-Pavagadh Archaeological Park	Gujarat	2004	Cultural
Chhatrapati Shivaji (शिवाजी) Maharaj Terminus	Maharashtra	2004	Cultural
Red Fort Complex	Delhi	2007	Cultural
Jantar Mantar, Jaipur	Rajasthan	2010	Cultural
Western Ghats	Multi-state	2012	Natural
Hill Forts of Rajasthan	Rajasthan	2013	Cultural
Rani-ki-Vav, Patan	Gujarat	2014	Cultural
Great Himalayan National Park	Himachal Pradesh	2014	Natural
Archaeological Site of Nalanda Mahavihara	Bihar	2016	Cultural
The Architectural Work of Le Corbusier (Capitol Complex)	Chandigarh	2016	Cultural (serial)
Khangchendzonga National Park	Sikkim	2016	**Mixed**
Historic City of Ahmadabad	Gujarat	2017	Cultural
Victorian Gothic and Art Deco Ensembles of Mumbai	Maharashtra	2018	Cultural
Jaipur City	Rajasthan	2019	Cultural
Kakatiya (काकतीय) Rudreshwara (Ramappa) Temple	Telangana	2021	Cultural
Dholavira: a Harappan City	Gujarat	2021	Cultural
Santiniketan	West Bengal	2023	Cultural
Sacred Ensembles of the Hoysalas	Karnataka	2023	Cultural
Moidams – Ahom mound-burial system	Assam	2024	Cultural
Maratha Military Landscapes of India	Maharashtra + Tamil Nadu	2025	Cultural
Ancient Buddhist Site of Sarnath	**UP**	2026	Cultural

Logic: India = 45. UP = 4 **(add** Sarnath 2026**).** Varanasi ghats ≠ WHS**. Only mixed =**

> Khangchendzonga**.

14.6 UNESCO Intangible Heritage List (India)

India has **16** UNESCO Representative List elements as of December **2025**. Learn each with year, name, and region.

- UNESCO first ran a **Masterpieces** programme. India got three: **Kutiyattam (2001)**, **Vedic chanting (2003)**, **Ramlila (2005)**.
- Those three entered the **Representative List in 2008**. A question can use either year. Do not treat 2001 and 2008 as two different elements.
- **Ramman (रम्माण) (2009)** is Garhwal (गढ़वाल) ritual theatre of **Uttarakhand**. It honours **Bhumiyal Devta** (भूमियाल देवता).
- Village communities stage masked ritual performance in the festival cycle — living heritage, not plains **Ramlila**.
- **Mudiyettu (मुडियेट्टु) (2010)** is Kerala ritual theatre. It is not Kathakali (कथकली).
- **Kalbelia (कालबेलिया) (2010)** is Rajasthan folk song (सोंग) and dance.
- **Chhau (छऊ) (2010)** is Jharkhand, West Bengal and Odisha. It is **not** an SNA classical dance.
- **Buddhist chanting of Ladakh (लद्दाख) (2012)** is Himalayan, not Sarnath.
- **Sankirtana (संकीर्तन) (2013)** is Manipur ritual singing, drumming and dancing.
- **Thatheras' brass and copper craft (2014)** is of **Jandiala Guru (गुरु), Punjab**.
- **Yoga (2016)** is pan-India. **Nawrouz (2016)** is multinational.
- **Kumbh Mela (2017)** is the four-site cycle: **Prayagraj, Haridwar (हरिद्वार), Nashik, Ujjain (उज्जैन)**. Pushkar is not a Kumbh site.
- **Durga Puja in Kolkata (2021)** is the named form. Generic Navratri (नवरात्रि) is not the inscription.
- **Garba of Gujarat (2023)** is the Navratri circle dance. It is not SNA classical.
- **Deepavali (10 December 2025)** is India's **16th** element. SNA prepared the file. 20.COM sat in New Delhi.

India ICH — complete Representative List (16)

Element	Year	Region
Kutiyattam (Koodiyattam (कूड़ियाट्टम्)), Sanskrit theatre	2001★ / RL 2008	Kerala
Tradition of Vedic chanting	2003★ / RL 2008	Pan-India
Ramlila, performance of the Ramayana (रामायण)	2005★ / RL 2008	North India, **UP** centre
Ramman, religious festival and ritual theatre	2009	Uttarakhand
Mudiyettu, ritual theatre and dance drama	2010	Kerala
Kalbelia folk songs and dances	2010	Rajasthan
Chhau dance	2010	JH / WB / Odisha

Element	Year	Region
Buddhist chanting of Ladakh	2012	Ladakh
Sankirtana of Manipur	2013	Manipur
Thatheras' brass and copper craft of Jandiala Guru	2014	Punjab
Nawrouz / Novruz	2016	Multinational
Yoga	2016	Pan-India
Kumbh Mela	2017	Four sacred cities
Durga Puja in Kolkata	2021	West Bengal
Garba of Gujarat	2023	Gujarat
Deepavali	2025	Pan-India

★ Masterpiece proclamation. RL = Representative List.

- UP's named ICH centrepiece is **Ramlila**. Prayagraj also hosts **Kumbh** (कुंभ). Yoga and Vedic chanting and Deepavali are pan-India, not UP-only.
- **Taj Mahal** is a WHS. Putting it on an ICH list is the classic wrong option.

> **Logic:** 16 elements. Deepavali 2025 **is in.** Ramlila = UP. Garba 2023. Bharatanatyam is still not listed**.